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## PILGRIMS CONVERGE ON MOUNT ARAFAT

■ Muslim pilgrims from around the world congregated on Mount Arafat in Saudi Arabia yesterday, the second official day of the annual Islamic pilgrimage, considered the pinnacle of Hajj. Despite the sweltering heat, the pilgrims gathered on the rocky hill and surrounding plain for intense prayers that often mark a spiritual peak. Typically, they fervently pray and pour their hearts out in supplications, asking God for forgiveness, mercy, blessings and good health. It is common for many pilgrims on that day to raise their hands in worship, with tears streaming down their faces.

SEE ALSO P3,5

AFP

### BUSINESS

**Emirates prepares for life after DXB with Dubai South expansion | P9**

### SPORT

**Aussie bowling legend Brett Lee calls IPL a 'nightmare' for bowlers | P14**



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# FRESH US STRIKES ON IRAN DEEPEN UNCERTAINTY AROUND PEACE PUSH

*Tehran threatens retaliation as Trump set for full cabinet meet*

### DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.

Senior Associate Editor

**F**resh US strikes on Iranian missile sites and suspected mine-laying boats have sharply escalated tensions with Tehran, threatening fragile diplomacy aimed at ending the war and reopening the Strait of Hormuz.

The early morning attacks came even as Iranian negotiators were in Qatar for talks on a possible peace agreement, underscoring the widening gap between public diplomacy and military realities on the ground.

The White House meanwhile said President Donald Trump would hold a rare full cabinet meeting at Camp David today as tensions with Iran intensify and negotiations remain uncertain.

Trump has repeatedly linked any settlement to reopening the Strait of Hormuz, effectively blockaded by Iran since April, disrupting global shipping and energy markets.

US Central Command said the renewed attacks were "self-defence strikes" carried out to protect American forces from threats posed by Iranian units near the Strait of Hormuz.

Iranian officials sought to

## GARGASH: UAE BUILT ON STRONG FOUNDATIONS

Dr Anwar Gargash, Diplomatic Adviser to the UAE President, said wars may create temporary challenges, but the UAE was built on strong foundations that make it more capable of remaining resilient and overcoming difficulties.

In a post on X, Gargash said the country's strength is rooted in "wise leadership, strong institutions, a competitive and advanced economy, and authentic values based on solidarity, tolerance and justice." Gargash added that the UAE's success "was not the product of coincidence, but the result of a deeply rooted vision and years of sincere and continuous work," stressing that the country is capable of overcoming challenges with confidence and stability.

— Gulf News Report

project strength, with Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei declaring that American military bases in the Middle East were no longer safe and warned regional countries against serving as "shields" for US forces.

### Iran warning

"The hands of time do not turn backward, and the nations and lands of the region will no longer serve as shields for American bases," Khamenei said in a written statement.

Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps separately warned it would retaliate against any further US attacks, saying a "reciprocal response" was "legitimate and certain".

The latest confrontation has

cast fresh doubt on claims that a deal could soon be reached.

While Secretary of State Marco Rubio said talks could produce an agreement within days, Trump struck a more cautious tone, saying there was "no hurry" and that the outcome would either be "great and meaningful" or "no deal".

At the same time, Iranian negotiators who left Qatar reportedly sought the release of around \$24 billion in frozen assets abroad under a proposed 14-point framework for ending the war.

Iran's Tasnim news agency reported that about \$12 billion would be released during the first phase of the agreement.

In another sign of shifting

conditions inside Iran, officials said restrictions on internet access imposed during the conflict would gradually be eased after months of severe disruption.

Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian has ordered the restoration of international internet access following an 87-day blackout that had largely cut off millions of Iranians from the outside world.

### Markets rattled

The latest strikes rattled financial markets after earlier optimism over a possible breakthrough had briefly pushed oil prices below \$100 a barrel. Brent crude rose more than three per cent yesterday after news of the attacks renewed fears that diplomacy could collapse.

American officials said the strikes targeted missile launch sites and boats allegedly attempting to place mines near Hormuz, while Iranian media reported explosions near Bandar Abbas, home to a major naval base overlooking the strategic waterway.

The renewed tensions suggest both sides continue to prepare for the possibility that talks could fail, even as negotiations move forward behind closed doors.

SEE ALSO P4, 6, 7, 11

## UAE slashes prices of 168 medicines

Discounts on cancer, diabetes and heart drugs to take effect from May 30

### ABU DHABI

BY ABDULLA RASHEED

Abu Dhabi Editor

**T**he Emirates Drug Establishment has approved price reductions for 168 pharmaceutical products across the UAE, targeting treatments for chronic and critical illnesses including cancer, diabetes, hypertension, heart disease, asthma, neurological disorders and glaucoma.

The revised pricing will take effect from May 30, with pharmacies across the UAE already updating prices to reflect the reductions. Discounts range from around 5 per cent to nearly 60 per cent, particularly for high-cost biologic and specialty medicines.

Among the biggest reductions was Zocor 40mg, a cholesterol-lowering medicine, whose price dropped by around 59.5 per cent.

Xalatan, used to treat elevated eye pressure in glaucoma patients, recorded the second-largest reduction at about 51.7 per cent.

### Significant cuts

Several cancer medicines also saw significant cuts. Alunbrig 180mg, prescribed for advanced non-small cell

Among the biggest reductions was Zocor 40mg, a cholesterol-lowering medicine, whose price dropped by around 59.5%.

lung cancer, was reduced from Dh26,433 to Dh21,108, while Alunbrig 90mg dropped from Dh19,824 to Dh12,520. Xeloda 150mg, used in breast, colon and rectal cancer treatment, fell from Dh347 to Dh241.

The decision also included lower prices for diabetes medicines such as Amaryl, heart failure therapies including Verquvo, blood pressure drugs like Renitec and Aprovel, and anticoagulants including Pradaxa.

Neurological and psychiatric treatments were also included. Invega 9mg, prescribed for schizophrenia and schizoaffective disorders, was reduced from Dh843 to Dh416, while Zeldox treatments also recorded major declines.

Eye medications such as Ganfort, Combigan and Xalatan were included in the reductions, alongside biologic asthma therapies including Nucala, which fell from Dh6,212.50 to Dh5,142.

SEE ALSO P7